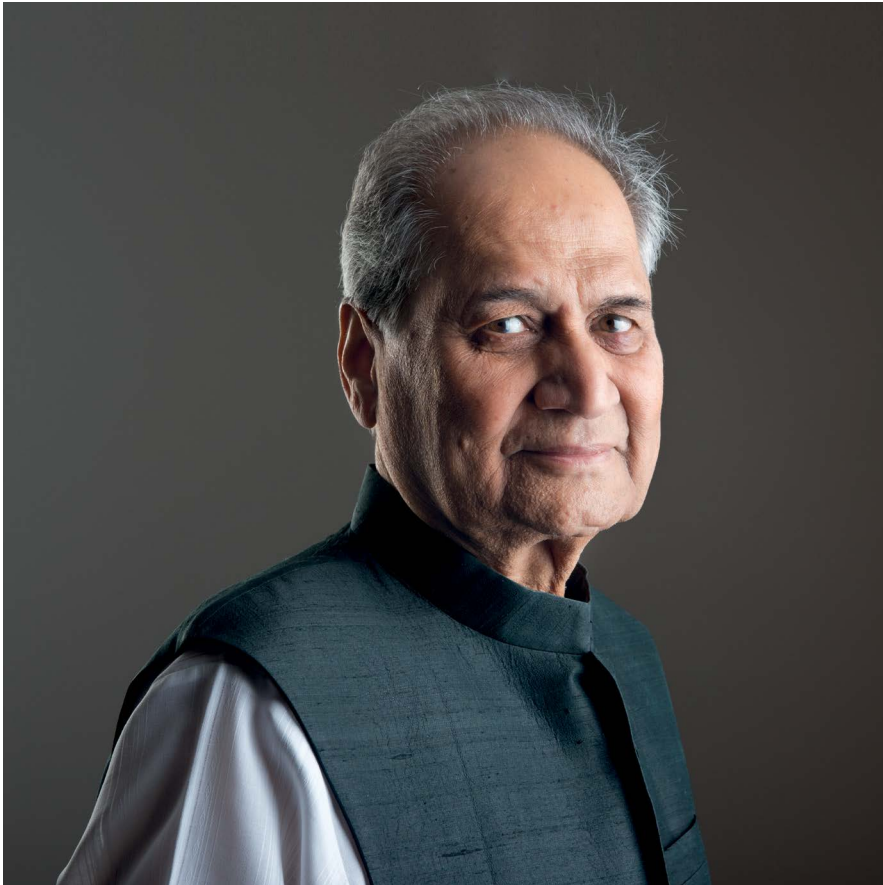


PHOTO BY **RACHIT GOSWAMI**



IN MEMORIAM Through the numerous voices in the book, Rahul Bajaj emerges as a visionary institution builder and a custodian of nationalist values

Ambani. For Ambani, Rahul Bajaj was a ‘yogi’, whose life was shaped by the rich legacy that he inherited from his family. “The Bajaj family is a proud and worthy inheritor of the legacy of India’s freedom movement. Mahatma Gandhi often described Jamnalal Bajaj, his close and trusted associate, as his ‘fifth son’. Thanks to this inheritance, Rahul-ji became one of the foremost votaries of the ‘nation first’ principle in Indian business,” Ambani notes. Tellingly, on more than one occasion Bajaj was vocal in his opposition to the Licence Raj, arguing that it stifled entrepreneurship and innovation. “Such was his determination to realise his mission that when the chains of the Licence Raj shackled him, he boldly declared that he would rather go to jail for excess production than slow down,” notes Ambani.

But Rahul Bajaj was also a staunch nationalist and a Gandhian. In fact, rooted in the Gandhian ethos, his commitment to ethical governance and social responsibility was unwavering. This point comes across sharply in the reminiscences of R. C. Bhargava,

Chairman of India’s biggest carmaker Maruti Suzuki Ltd. As Bhargava notes, “He could achieve low costs of production and high profitability because of his ethical and frugal management style.” Moreover, Bhargava says, beyond the boardroom, Rahul Bajaj’s deep-seated commitment to nationalism propelled him to serve as a conscience keeper of the nation, challenging policies that hindered India’s industrial growth, while advocating for inclusive development.

But what about Rahul Bajaj the human being? For veteran industrialist Jamshyd Godrej, Chairman and Managing Director of Godrej & Boyce, Rahul Bajaj was a man whose warmth and generosity endeared him to all. “He was genuinely interested in people, had a phenomenal memory, and loved to talk.” In fact, Rahul Bajaj’s friendships were as legendary as his leadership, characterised by loyalty, camaraderie, and a zest for

life that illuminated “every room he entered”.

The legacy of Rahul Bajaj, who passed away in 2022 at the age of 83, remains etched in the annals of history as a beacon of hope and inspiration for generations to come. Historian Sugata Bose reflects on his lasting imprint, writing that “his memory will never fade”. As Bose puts it, Rahul Bajaj’s life serves as a testament to the transformative power of vision, integrity, and leadership. But it also serves as a testament to a particular kind of business leadership: one that has ethics and values at its core.

As we read these numerous voices, each unique in its understanding of Rahul Bajaj, both as a person and as a business leader, the man emerges not just as a titan of industry but also as a visionary institution builder, a custodian of nationalist values, and a cherished friend whose legacy transcends time and space. In short, he was a man who contained multitudes within him. **BT**

@arnav_d